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Geneva

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*, written in 1818, is largely set in Geneva, the bustling, neat, clean, clockwork-organized Swiss city where I now made my home. Like many Americans, I'd grown up watching the various movie versions and TV cartoons, but I'd never actually read the book. In the days before I left the States, however, I'd been searching for what to read about Geneva, and in nearly all the lists I found online, *Frankenstein* stood out from among the tourist guides and histories. In fact, I think the only PDFs I downloaded for the flight over were *Frankenstein* and the Geneva Conventions, and I only finished the former. I did my reading at night over the long, lonely months I spent by myself before Lindsay moved over to join me, stretched out on a bare mattress in the living room of the comically fancy, comically vast, but still almost entirely unfurnished apartment that the embassy was paying for on the Quai du Seujet, in the Saint-Jean Falaises district, with the Rhône out one window and the Jura Mountains out the other.

Suffice it to say, the book wasn't what I expected. *Frankenstein* is an epistolary novel that reads like a thread of overwritten emails, alternating scenes of madness and gory murder with a cautionary account of the way technological innovation tends to outpace all moral, ethical, and legal restraints. The result is the creation of an uncontrollable monster.

In the Intelligence Community, the "Frankenstein effect" is widely cited, though the more popular military term for it is "blowback": situations in which policy decisions intended to advance American interests end up harming them irreparably. Prominent examples of the "Frankenstein effect" cited by after-the-fact civilian, governmental, military, and even IC assessments have included America's funding and training of the mujahideen to fight the Soviets, which resulted in the radicalization of Osama bin Laden and the founding of al-Qaeda, as well as the de-Baathification of the Saddam Hussein–era Iraqi military, which